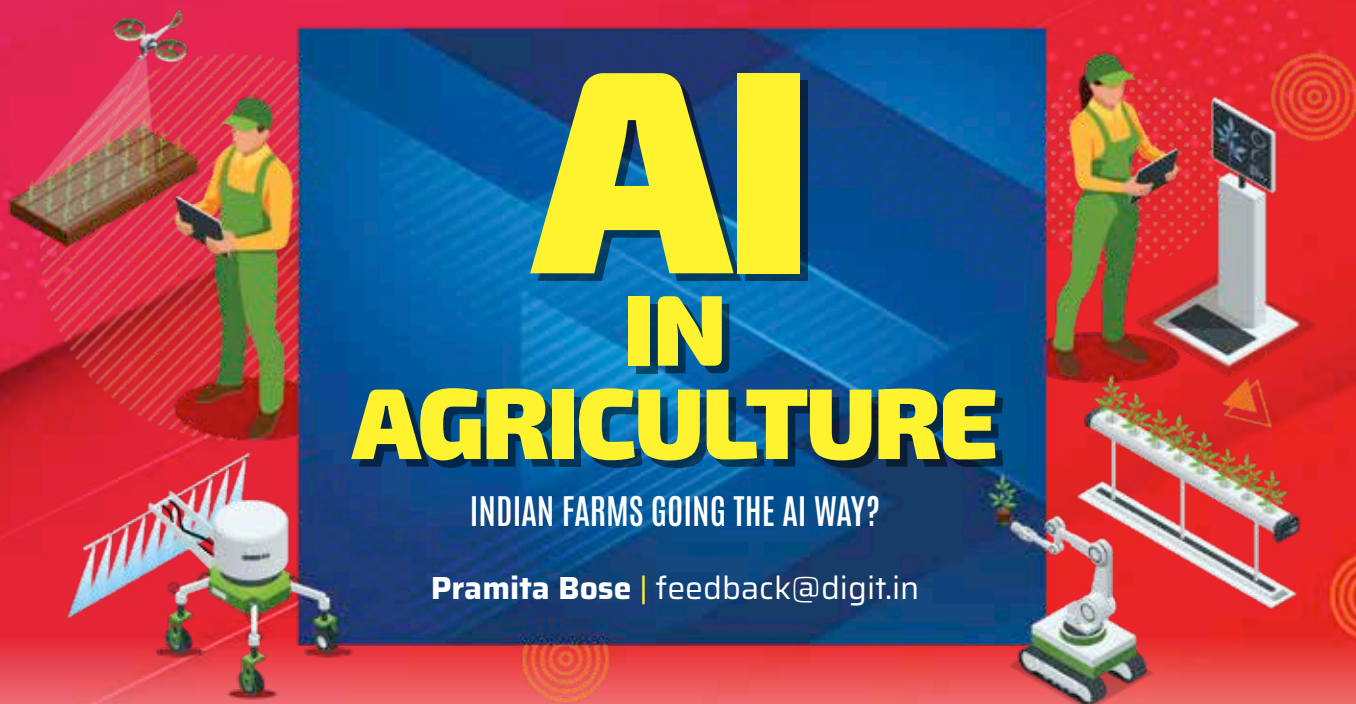




From farm to fork, food is being processed not only organically but also using technology to attain better quality. While eyebrows are often raised at the addition of preservatives to extend the shelf life of packaged, canned and tinned food, the ingress of agritech via integration of artificial intelligence is a welcome advancement for agriculture. Since India's backbone is still its farmers, AI holds the key to revolutionising the lives of farmers in India.

AI: The New Farming Tool

Agri-tech players introduce advanced technology to the traditional methods of farming and cultivation for higher yield, efficiency, sustainability and profitability. Quite frequently employed in horticulture and agriculture, this cutting-edge technique is also applied to forestry, aquaculture and viticulture.

State-of-the-art AI can detect plant diseases, pests, insects, locusts and chemical fertilizers, zoom in on malnourished farms, recognise plots of lands thirsty of irrigation and ascertain the urgency of treatment with fertilizers or pesticides. It can also incorporate innovation through vertical agriculture to ramp up output, reduce the use of

exhaustive natural resources, predict seasons compatible with sowing and harvesting, and more.

Hi-tech in Agri-tech

AI takes away the mundane and clerical work of statistical gathering and parsing of data, not just throwing up prettified and human-readable data, but also suggesting solutions and giving advice!

"Leveraging AI in the agricultural sector can unfurl a slew of benefits," highlights Rashi Gupta, Chief Data Scientist and co-founder of REZO.AI, an AI-powered contact center, aiding crop breeders in more ways than one. The company's AI-driven CX cloud is conver-

sant with vernaculars, thus providing a customized assistance to planters by conveying relevant information to them on crucial factors like temperature, probability of rain, the best time to sow seeds and the wind speed.

Speaking of the AI utility in agriculture, Rajesh Aggarwal, Managing Director, Insecticides India Ltd, one of India's leading agrochemicals manufacturing companies, says "Artificial Intelligence is the future of agriculture. Technologies, such as Machine Learning (ML), deep learning and computer vision are reinventing every sector, boosting productivity and efficiency, and agriculture is undoubtedly an integral part of this nucleus."

AI drones are the latest trend adopted by the agricultural sector and agro-industries worldwide, and they're being used to spray insecticides with far superior precision than before, and without needing the farmers to be in their fields. AI also reduces many other forms of manual labour, including keeping vigil on their crops, locating weeds, and also monitoring conditions. "There are a number of open source solutions, such as the GIS software suite GRASS with useful algorithms for AI farming applications," says senior solutions architect Mallory Dodd of iMerit Technology, a

